



Panama

The blue and red represent the country's two main political parties.

About 14,000 ships pass through the canal every year.



Festive clothing

Girls in Panama are given their first pollera dress at the age of 16. Worn at festivals and celebrations, this decorative dress has colorful embroidery.



- 29,120 sq miles (75,420 sq km)
- 3.9 million
- Panama City
- English Creole, other languages (+3)

Known as the “**Crossroads of the Americas**,” Panama lies on the **strip of land** linking **Central** and **South America**. An **artificial waterway** cuts across the country, linking the **Pacific** and **Atlantic oceans**.

Ocean shortcut
The Panama Canal opened in 1914. Some 50 miles (82 km) long, it allows shipping to avoid the lengthy and dangerous journey around South America.



Cuba

The star symbolizes Cuba's independence from Spain in 1898 and the US in 1902.

Colorful snail
Polymita snails are found only in the forests of Cuba.



Cuban capital
Havana is the biggest city in the Caribbean and a major port. The historic old town is very popular with tourists.



Vintage cars
For years the import of cars to Cuba was banned. Many on the streets are vintage American cars, used as taxis.

Colorful houses with crumbling facades are common in Havana's older quarters.



Cuba is the **largest island** in the **Caribbean Sea**. It is also one of the few **socialist republics** in the world. **Tourism** and **agriculture** are its main industries, and **sugar**, **tobacco**, and **citrus fruits** are some of its **major exports**.

- 42,803 sq miles (110,860 sq km)
- 11.1 million
- Havana
- Spanish